

The Wailing Whale

—“Today, children, I am going to tell you a tale about...” a little pause to get them all to hold their breath, “how the Princess and her Knight find the Wailing Whale.”

Yay! A story of the Princess and the Knight. But what’s a wailing whale?

—“Tell us, Varaz!”

“One day, the Princess and her Knight go for a stroll on the beach. The sand between their toes feels warm, washed away with waves of whooshing water. It’s a nice day and they walk hand-in-hand enjoying Spring’s soothing shimmering sun. But what is that there, a bit further along the shore? It looks like a giant fish. And when they come closer, they can see it has tears in its eyes. It’s a whale, and it is singing this very sad song sounding so sorrowful. It makes you almost cry too.

~“*Drōd* [Hello]! I am the Princess and this is my Knight.” The whale stops sobbing and makes a little bob with his head—but its head, it’s so big that water splashes all over them.

~“Oh, sorry. *Drōd*, I am Younā [Jonas] the Whale.”

~“Younā? I thought Younā was the one inside...” The Princess puts her hand on his arm and shakes her head. So, he stops talking. You see, children, whales don’t like to be contradicted.

~“It’s a great honor to meet you *Pappos* [grandpa] Younā. But why are you sad?”

~“Well, I used to be somebody you know. Everyone would look up to me,” he shakes his head, causing more splashing onto our two heroes, “Yeah, I was a big fish...”

~“But are you not still a...” Once more, the princess has to stop the Knight from continuing.

~“... a big fish in service of the Lord of the Heavens and the Sky. But the Lord of the Heavens and the Sky ... he wants to retire, and I will become like poor Job, jobless.” The Knight has to refrain himself from making another comment. Be-

cause, remember children, you should never contradict a whale.⁷¹

—“Why not, Varaz?”

—“Because then they start to woefully wail and wutheringly whine. And trust me, cod tears, they don’t smell that well.”

⌈But the princess is surprised—since when do Gods retire, she wonders?

~“The Lord of the Heavens and the Sky has retired? How can you be certain?”

~“He sent me his Ten Amendments.”

~“Ten Amendments? How?”

~“There, those clay tablets, near that burnt-out bush. When I started reading them, I . . . I couldn’t anymore,” the Princess shouldn’t have asked, for now Younā cannot hold himself anymore, “Waaah.” Our two heroes run to the bush—away from those smelly tears. But the stone tablets, they are in a language they cannot read, so they take them back to the whale.

~“What do they say, Pappos Younā? We cannot read them.”

~“Oh, right, they’re in Whalish. But they are all wrong, Princess! The Lord, he has . . . changed. Take this one.”

Firstly, thou mayest have many gods after Me.

~“It’s the opposite from what He used to say. Or, this one, it’s just . . .”

Secondly, thou mayest sing My name in the rain.

~“I don’t even know what that means!” And then he reads out aloud the other tablets, each time shaking his head, making our duo wetter and wetter.

Thirdly, on sabbath, dost not call for I shall be unavailable

Fourthly, dost not embarrass your children

Fifthly, thou mayest kill the time with silly games

Sixthly, thou mayest eat pork with poultry

*Seventhly, thou mayest mix iron with steel
Eighthly, thou mayest say hello to your neighbor
or ninthly, borrow his tallest ladder
But tenthly, his wife, that remains a big no-no-er!*

~“See, they make no sense.”

~“So, perhaps better he has retired then, *Pappos Younā*?”

~“I guess you’re right, Princess. But now I am out of job. A porpoise without purpose.”

~“If I may ask, *Pappos Younā*, what did you do for the Lord of the Heavens and the Sky?”

~“Swallow heathen and spit out pious.”

~“Huh?”

~“Whoever scorned the Lord, the Lord would throw in the sea, and then I would scoop him—or her—up. And for three days, he or she would fast in my belly—apparently humans do not like krill too much—and after a three day’s cleansing fast, the Lord’s wisdom would be revealed to them and they would recant. And then, I would spit them back out at the gates of *Nainavā* [Nineveh].”

~“*Nainavā*?”

~“Yes, it’s a city. . .”

~“I know that! But it is where Queen *Shamiram* has her palace!”

~“Ah, yes, Queen *Shamiram*. Quite the woman, he? *Alā*, in the old days, she used to be good, you know, formidable, yes, funny too, fancy yet fair, frivolous yet feisty, ferocious yet fragrant, fantastic yet fantastical. But nowadays, up is down and left is right. I don’t even know anymore where my tail is!” The Knight wants to show *Younā*, but the Princess shakes her head. Of course, he knows where his tail is. . .⁷¹

Varaz grabs his ears.

—“Like as if we would ever forget where our noses are.”

—“Ha, ha, Varaz, we only have one nose.”

—“That’s true. I guess the sorry story of *Younā* the wailing whale has me all confoundedly confused.”

⌈ But the Princess, she wants to help. And so she offers

~“We were thinking of visiting Nainavā ourselves...”

~“We were?” The Princess looks sternly at the Knight—yeah, it appears our Knight is not too familiar with proper piscatory protocol...[†]

—“Varaz, why are you doing these silly words?”

To put to practice his newest lessons from his music teacher.

*The illiterate take everything literally
while the literate prefer to alliterate
yet a rock-n-rolling rhyme
that always attracts attention.*

After which his mentor would add the enigmatic

~“So, young Varaz, as long as what you say is not just the words you utter.” That’s why he loves master Pahrbad’s lessons, ha, ha. Yet, he is not even his favorite music teacher. But his favorite one, Nagisā, well, that is for an entirely different reason, one not suited for children’s ears. That Nagisā, she makes him even forget his own princess! But talking about the Princess, what was she about to say again?

—“So, that if you skip one word, you wouldn’t forget the next.”

—“That makes no sense!”

—“Yet, Shirowe, ...”

†The Princess still remembers what she was going to propose

~“You could take us in your belly, *Pappos* Younā, it would be a great honor.” The Knight looks horrified at his companion: is she proposing that they are going to spend three days in the belly of a whale? She nods at him reassuringly—I don’t think though he is all that convinced. But he knows by now not to contradict.

~“Honestly, an honor it will be. Unless, of course, it’s too much to ask...” But Younā is exhilarated.

~“You will be my passengers,” he claps his fins together from enthusiasm, splashing even more on our adventurous duo—they are by now soaking wet, “It will be like old times. Yay! ..., hmm, and perhaps, ... afterwards, there is this nice pond near the gates of Nainavā. I can see myself retire there, no?”

~“Alright! Then it is set. We’re going to Nainavā,” and then she whispers in her Knight’s ears, “to pay our villainous queen a surprise visit, ha, ha.” Younā opens up his big mouth and ... they step inside. Past the tongue and the baleen, through the throat, keeping left—they don’t want to end up in his liver, you know, quite smelly—until they reach the first stomach.

~“Wow. The inside is so much bigger than the outside!”[¶]

—“It’s true, children, so much bigger on the inside!”

—“Varaz, how is that possible?”

—“Whalish Time-And-Relative-Dimensions-In-Space magic or something like that.”

[¶] And there are oil lamps burning everywhere, and the Princess exclaims

~“Oh, how nice. The ulcers are in bloom!”

~“And look a little pond with *sepia* [cuttlefish] playing hide-and-seek.”

~“Oh yes, that’s funny. They spray ink in their friends’ eyes, and then they cannot find each other, ha, ha.” But then the Princess remembers something, and she runs back out.

~“*Pappos* Younā, are we not in the sea of the Romans?”

~“Yes, we are.”

~“But to go to Nainavā, do we not have to go via the sea of the Persians?”

~“Indeed.”

~“But there is no river nor canal that connects both!”

~“Aha, that’s where you wrong Princess. In the old days, the *Shāhān-Shāh* of the Persians built a canal from one sea to the other.”

~“I have heard that being told. But that canal is no more.”

~“Oh, you didn’t know? They moved it!” The Princess is puzzled, how can you move a canal?

~“So, where is it now?”

~“Well, obviously the same way! You still wanna go from one sea to the other, right?”

~“Huh?”

~“It’s underground. We moved it into the ground and now

we call it the Subwater. I'll show you when we get there." The Princess is not really convinced, but being the whale's guest, she shrugs her shoulders and goes back inside. And so Younā tells his guests:

~"Welcome aboard, passengers, this is your whale speaking. Please buckle up and sit tight. We're taking off." The whale's voice sounds a little eerie from inside his belly, but they both sit down on a bench made out of colorful shells. And so, after spending a couple of hours in the whale's belly—the bobbing and bouncing is not really the Knight's favorite and he is getting quite pale—they stop and the whale announces ~"Dear passengers, we reached our destination: the Subterranean Underground Express Zone. Please exit! Through the mouth, please! The rear is for emergencies only. " When the Princess and the Knight step out of Younā's mouth, he points to a big sign in red letters.

~"I can't read it, *Pappos* Younā. Is it Whalish?"

~"Oh, right, I keep forgetting that humanity has lost mastery of that beautiful tongue," and to show them, he sticks out his big pink tongue, "It says that the Persian *Shāhān-Shāh* ordered this canal to be dug, so that people can go from Egypt through this canal to Persia, as he had intended.²⁴ And then it says that that way is upwater, and the other way is downwater. We're obviously going downwater."

~"I thought we have to go down the ground?"

~"Yes, of course, it's just an expression: downwater means towards the sea of the Persians."

~"Why is that down?"

~"Because the other direction is up." But before the Knight can raise an objection, the Princess quickly asks.

~"And why are the letters red?"

~"Well, this is the Red Line. It goes to the Red Sea."

~"Oh, are there more lines?"

~"Yes, the Black Line."

~"Oh, wow, it goes all the way to the Black sea?"

~"No, why would you think that! It goes to the underworld.

²⁴Darius, Shaluf Stela.

But it is still under construction and for now, it only goes one way." The Knight raises his finger, so the Princess quickly drags him with her down the stairs before he makes another goof-up. When they arrive in the subterranean station, they see a canal running through the station and disappearing in a tunnel.

~"Oh, we're in luck. The next train is arriving." And indeed, a train of camels comes out of one side of the tunnel, dragging several barges with them. And in the barges, there are pools, with fish and other sea creatures swimming around.

~"This is our ride?"

~"Yes, nice, no? Luckily it's not rush hour. That's when all the dolphins and the salmon start migrating. They are so noisy. Always jumping up and down, pff. Look that pool is almost empty," but just as the Princess and the Knight want to step into the barge Younā has pointed to, he quickly pulls them back, "oh, no, we can't go there."

~"Why not?"

~"That one is reserved for sharks! Come this one is nice too. Come swim with me. The water is nice and salty."

~"Uhm, no thank you, we will just sit here on the side, if you don't mind."

~"Suit yourself." And Younā plunges himself next to a giant squid, who looks a little annoyed by the newcomers, but doesn't say anything. So, they all sit in the barge, when the camels slowly start moving. One step... another step—oh, dear, this is going to take forever—but then another step ... and another... and one more... 𐀀

He starts talking faster and faster, making the children laugh—even little Shasha on the *Bāmbishn*'s lap is crowing.

𐀀 And woosh, all of sudden they are speed-barging! Who knew camels can walk this fast! And before they know it, they're on the other side. A voice announces.

~"We reached our final destination. Queen Arsinoë awaits you." The Princess and the Knight look surprised at Younā.

~"The Queen will greet us in person?"

~"Which Queen?"

~“Well, didn’t the announcer say Queen Arsinoë?”

~“Oh, I see, ha, ha. No, Queen-Arsinoë-Awaits-You is just the name of the place. It’s a port on the Red Sea and from here we will set whale for Persia.”

~“What a strange name for a city.”

~“Oh, the story goes that long time ago, there once was a princess in the land of Egypt and her name was Arsinoë. And her uncle was *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander [Alexander] and he wanted to give her in marriage to his friend, prince Body-wrapper. But Arsinoë was not so fond of him, and so she went to her uncle, and she asked ‘Can you not give me in marriage to someone else?’ And so *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander did, for he liked his niece very much, and he married her to her own brother Thunderbolt. But Thunderbolt was always mean to her and so, she went again to her uncle. ‘Why did you marry me to my mean brother?’ And Iskander said, ‘I did? Oops, my mistake. I will see to it that you marry the Brother-who-Loves.’ That was his name and Arsinoë became the beloved of the Holy Ram, Goddess, the Beloved of her royal brother.²⁵ And as a wedding gift, her groom told her ‘Arsinoë, I want to give you a city. I have a couple left on the shores of the Red Sea. Just pick one and it will be yours.’ And Arsinoë was ecstatic—she was going to get her own city—and so, when she came to this shore, she told her servants to go to the governor of the city and say that ‘Queen Arsinoë awaits you’, and that’s how the city got its name. Nice, no? Oh, we whales have this beautiful saying.”

*Whoop whoopidy flop
wheep wheepidy flip
whoopy whoop floop
wheepy-whoopy-noopy fleep.*

Younā looks at our two heroes to see the effect of his poem, but all he gets is a blank stare. He realizes.

~“I keep forgetting! You guys don’t speak Whalish. Allow me to translate for you. Of course much will be lost in translation, but you’ll get the gist.”

²⁵Mendes stele.

*Where wondrous facts
would wistfully flail
with wisecracking fiction,
will wonderment not fail.*

They politely clap, but I don't think our Knight believes much of the story. Luckily, he is wise enough not to say anything, because...²⁶

—"You don't contradict a whale!"

The others shout out in unison. But she is a little preoccupied with the Princess's story. If she were to be Arsinoë, she knows who Thunderbolt would be: her obnoxious brother Shirowe. Luckily, it's just a story.

—"So, did they get to our country, Varaz?"

⌈The whale explains

~"We're going to have to make a few stops on the way."

~"To get some provisions?"

~"To get some air!"

~"Ah, right. That's important too, ha, ha."

~"Besides, passengers are supposed to abide by the three-day long fast of Nainavā. The *Katolikos* has said so himself: 'let the blind lead the blind,'²⁶ and let the fast follow the fast. So, no foods for you guys," he notices the Knight's disheartened look, so he whispers, "I secretly stored some figs in my third stomach, all the way in the back. You can have those. But don't overindulge, because they make you feel funny." And so they are on their way again. And after a long voyage, Younā's belly voice announces.

~"We reached the Port of Adulation. Dear passengers, please exit through the mouth," and in a booming voice he adds, "The rear is for emergencies only! King *Negus* awaits you."

So, they step out again and the Knight asks

~"So this place, it is called King-*Negus*-Awaits-You?" The whale looks puzzled at him.

~"Why would you say that? I told you, this is the Port of Adulation. And look, there, the elephant King *Negus*, he is coming to greet you." Indeed, they can see in the distance

²⁶Ezekiel, sermon.

men carrying a platform with a throne on it. Its gold shimmers in the sun.

~“Is he called the Elephant King because he has so many elephants?”

~“I don’t think so, my Knight, look!” And now that they have come closer, they see that on the throne sits a huge elephant, carrying a golden crown on his head, and a little silver tiara on the tip of his trunk.

~“Greetings, noble Younā. When news reached Us of your impending visit, bringing us the illustrious Princess and her Knight, we hastened to Our port for the proper adulation.”

~“Princess, I think the Elephant King came to pay homage to you,” the Knight whispers, but Younā looks very sternly at him. Now he gets it, “I mean, the other way around.” And so they reverently bow seven times in front of the the Elephant King. [⌈]

—“Why seven, Varaz?”

—“Younā has told them to do so.”

⌈The Princess thinks, it will be once for every day of the week. But the Knight figures, we bow once for every planet in the sky. But then they look up and they realize, it is once for every eye of the King! [⌈]

—“Elephants do not have seven eyes!”

—“Royal ones apparently do, so as puzzled as you guys are. . .”

⌈The Knight asks

~“Your Elevated Elephantine Excellency, how come you have seven eyes? Is it one for every planet in the sky?” And the Princess adds

~“Or one for every day of the week?” But King *Negus* replies, although his tone is not too friendly—for as bad as contradicting a whale is, contraposing an elephant is worse.

~“Why would you say that! Is it not known in all the lands that We have seven eyes to watch the seven archangels who stand in Our glorious presence, ready to serve Us.²⁷ All the land, as far as you can see, on this side of the Red Sea, is

²⁷Tobit, 12.15.

under Our command. And then We sent a fleet to the *Tāzig* [Arab] who live across the Red Sea and forced their kings to submit, We commanded them to pay tribute for their land and to keep the peace by land and sea and We waged war in the land of Sheba.²⁸

~“Your Massive Majestic Majesty, you then command both sides of the Sea?” That just makes the King even more angry. Children, I think in this story, the Knight better not talk too much more before he gets the whole animal kingdom on his head.

~“You insolent Knave, are you making fun of Us!” Luckily, Younā decides to come to his passengers’ rescue.

~“Your Excellency. Please forgive the ignorance of these humans. Like children, they are not paying attention to the flux and flow of time, oblivious to the swinging and swaying of the Pendulum of Fate, and so, they do not know that a great evil has risen in the city of Sanā—O the insanity! They do not know that the Lion Queen of Sheba is sitting in her high tower in Sanā—O the insanctity.”

~“The queen is a lioness?” The whale looks surprised at our Knight—oh, no, children, another blunder of our Knight!

~“Why would you think that? Of course not, she is the Queen who rules over the Arabs and the Jews and all the lions in between. Have you not heard of her Four Roaring Lions,” and then shaking his head, “such ignoramuses—I never should have agreed to take you in my belly!”

~“Forgive my companion, dear *Pappos* Younā, the impetuosity of his youth. We would love to hear about the Four Roaring Lions of the Queen of Sheba.”

~“Alright, since you’re a princess—I must admit, in my old day, I’ve grown a soft spot for princesses—as long as they do not turn into evil queens,” and turning to the Knight, “accompanied by lying Knaves...”

~“Oh, no, *Pappos* Younā, I never would. A noble Princess I shall remain and he my valiant Knight.”

~“Alright then. I will tell you about the calamity that has

²⁸Adulis inscription.

befallen the land across the sea. In that land, there is a beautiful city, Sanā is its name, and in that city proudly stands a tower, twenty stories high, built with bricks in all sorts of color, its dome made from alabaster, so that it shines like the sun during the day and glows like the moon at night. Verily, its builders raised it to the flying clouds.²⁹ And the Lion Queen of Sheba desires to rule the land from atop that tower. But how is she going to get there? And then she hears about the magic carpet of Solomon. That'll work! And so, she comes to King Solomon to test him with hard riddles.³⁰ But the King fails to solve them, and so she takes his magical carpet, and with it she flies to the high tower in the castle. And with her, she brings her Four Roaring Lions, to guard her day and night," he looks our duo up and down, "but before I initiate you in the secret of the Four Roaring Lions, I—like the Queen of Sheba tested Solomon—must now test your acuity. Are you wiser than King Solomon? Because this revelation is not just for anyone's ears!" So, Younā the whale poses them a riddle they have to solve before he continues his story. He tells them of this contraption that sits in the middle of the Queen's room in the high tower in her capital Sanā. ٧

He turns slightly to the girls, so that he can keep a better eye on Abrangih's reaction. She was already shuffling a little nervously on her cushion, when he mentioned the city of Sanā and its tower. But unlike last time, he didn't give the fortress's name away: Gamdan. He has designed this part of his narration as a test, to see whether the girl really has been inside that Gamdan palace, not just heard of it

—"I think, guys, we should help them solve the riddle. So that we may hear the story of the Four Roaring Lions too."

—"Yes, Varaz, tell us the riddle. We will solve it!"

—"Alright then, children. What do you think it is that sits in the middle of the room?"

*Its water's well
for thirst to quell*

²⁹Adiyi, poem.

³⁰1 Kings, 10:1.

*but with a spell
time it will tell.*

What could that be? She feels an elbow poking in her side. It's Abrangih and she ... *pargast*, she knows. She whispers.

—"What, Abrangih, what is it?"

—"It's a waterclock, Borān, but don't tell."

Why wouldn't she tell? That's the whole purpose. So, she decides to ignore her friend's protests.

—"It's a waterclock, Varaz!"

—"Very good, Borān," he has noticed the little exchange of the two girls—and since Persians are not supposed to lie, he can get the answer he is looking for, "How did you know, Borān?"

—"Abrangih! She knew. It was Abrangih who solved it."

But that revelation makes her friend hide her face between her hands. She is way too modest!

—"That was very smart of her," eureka, that proves it! The girl has seen that most extraordinary feature of the Gamdan palace, the waterclock, the ancient time-measuring device that had been constructed in it.³¹ He is now convinced that she comes from that place, and since she calls herself a princess, she is probably related to his friend Xorra-Xosrow. Meanwhile, the poor girl has crawled behind Borān, out of his sight, but he got what he wanted from her, "So, let's hear then..."

┌ The story of the Four Roaring Lions:

~"High in her tower, the Lion Queen, she keeps as her bodyguards four enormous lions. The first one shines all white, carrying the Bow of Antichrist and his name is Gabrielywār, the one who has returned to take away insight and understanding.³² The second one reveals himself as the red warrior who carries the Sword of Strife and his name is Miḫāelywār, the one who will return to fight against the princes of Persia.³³ The third one is all black, carrying the Scales of Injustice and is called Raphaelywār, who has returned to inflict all the diseases and all the wounds to the children of

³¹Hamdani, Book VIII.

³²Daniel 9:21.

³³Daniel 10:20.

men.³⁴ And the fourth one is as pale as the Dead Sea of Hades and his name is Urielχwār, the one who has returned to rule over the world and over Tartarus.³⁵ Those are the Four Roaring Lions of the Queen of Sheba and she has given them each authority over a quarter of the tower, to kill with sword, famine and plague, and by means of the beasts of the Earth.³⁶ And they are sitting high on a pedestal, one in each corner, ready to jump upon the unsuspecting visitor: one wrong word, and the Queen gives her lions the sign. And if their loud roar does not make your heart stop, their claws and maw will turn you into their supper very quickly. So, Knight of Malaprop, as you are prone to put your foot into your mouth, I don't think you should go there."

~"I don't think so, either, *Pappos* Younā. We'd better stay in your belly as you circumnavigate that dangerous country."

~"So, then I will." After saying goodbye to the Elephant King *Negus* at the Port of Adulation—he still looks a little angry at the Knight, so he quickly slips into Younā's mouth—they continue their journey inside the stomach of the whale. Nibbling on the figs Younā has stowed away in his third stomach. But as Younā has forewarned them, if you eat too many, you fall asleep and get the weirdest dreams.[†]

—"Well, we should not violate the privacy of their dreams, children, so let me not divulge them. Though, trust me, they are very weird, wild and wayward."

—"Owh!"

The main reason he is not going to tell about their dreams is, well, because, he hasn't prepared this part yet. He was so focused on getting to trick the *Abrangih* girl, that he never wrote the conclusion of the story. So, there were soon to follow a few more disappointing owhs and awhs.

† And so, unawares, they pass through the Gates of Persia, travel up the Tigris river all the way up ...until they are awoken by a sudden
~"Ow! Ow ! Ow!"[†]

³⁴1 Enoch, 1:33.

³⁵1 Enoch, 20:2.

³⁶Revelations, 7.

—“Oh, no!,” he steps to the window and pretends to look outside, “I think I know what happened.”

—“What, Varaz?”

—“Yep, it’s like I thought. I just saw Younā shake his head.”

That makes them all run to the window. But even jumping up and down, it is too high to see outside. For once, their brother could be of some help!

—“Shirowe, you’re the biggest. Go look.”

—“There is nothing there, dummy. Varaz’s just pulling your leg.”

—“Well, I don’t know about you, Shirowe, but I just saw with my own eyes a whale swim. . .”

⌈The Princess wants to know too.

~“What happened, *Pappos* Younā.”

~“I hit my head. On those stupid Bridges of Commotion.”

~“What bridges are that?”⌋

—“We all know, don’t we, children, that those are the ones outside there.” They all look confused.

—“The two bridges over the river, to Veh Ardashir?,” she’s pretty sure of it, “They’re not called the Bridges of Commotion, Varaz!”

True, they are just called ‘the bridges’ by everyone. But there is this funny story. . .

—“*Alā*, I am not so sure, Borān. See, originally, there was only one bridge.”

⌈But then in the days of *Shāhān-Shāh* Shāpur, your ancestor, when he was still a little boy, like you guys. He couldn’t sleep. And so he went to complain to his *darigbed* [major-domo].

~“Why do the people always make so much noise on that bridge?”

~“Because some Jewish ladies are coming from Veh Ardashir to do some shopping in the bazaar of Tisfon, and some fish-mongers are going the opposite way, to sell their salted fish to the *Tarsāg* [Christian]. And now they are blocking each other’s way. And there is also one brother who wants to go hither and the other wants to go thither. So, Your Majesty, everyone is yelling at everyone on the bridge to make way.”

~“Well, that is unacceptable. Let it be decreed that I, *Shāhān-Shāh* Shāpur—crowned king before born man—that I order

there to be built another bridge,³⁷ to stop this mad commotion. And on one bridge, the good people of Tisfon will walk in the direction of Veh Ardashir, and return to their homes via the other bridge. And the same for the good people of Veh Ardashir." And so, young *Shāhān-Shāh* Shāpur thought that he had solved the problem.⁷¹

—"Didn't he, Varaz?"

He leans outside the window.

—"I just heard a donkey braying at a page and an old lady cursing a little boy. So, I don't think it really worked. You know what the problem is?"

—"No, what, Varaz?"

—"Hmm, I think your ancestor forgot something."

—"What, Varaz?"

—"To specify who is supposed to take which bridge."

—"Huh?"

⁷¹So, after the decree, the good people of Veh Ardashir diligently take the northern bridge to visit their cousins in Tisfon. But the wine merchant from Tisfon who wants to sell his jars in the bazaar of Veh Ardashir, he takes the same bridge. And so, when they reach the middle of the bridge, they clash into each other. And in the evening, when the merchant returns home, he takes the southern bridge—as decreed by the *Shāhān-Shāh*—, and—bang!—he runs again into the cousins returning home, for they too have obeyed the law and took the other bridge to return. But now, they angrily shout at each other and call each other names I should not repeat here. See, children, even *Shāhān-Shāh* cannot counteract the commotion of the commonwealth.⁷¹

—"We should tell daddy, Borān, to fix it."

Oh, no! Her sister stepped in the trap and now Shirowe is going to . . .

—"You're so dumb, Āzar! Varaz, is just pulling your leg. There is no such decree."

She looks furiously at her brother and then at him, so he quickly hastens to tell the rest of the story—not much left anyway, for lack of preparation.

—"I don't think Younā the whale can hear you guys anymore. He had

³⁷Tabari, 837.

enough commotion for the day, ha, ha.”

ⲓ So, he has swam on. And now, they are approaching the city of Nainavā, so he announces.

~“Dear passengers, we reached our final destination, the city of Nainavā. Just keep in mind that

*We are sinners and guilty ones
before You, our Lord, we fall down.
Upon Your mercies we rely,
like Nainavā who repented.*³⁸

And now, please exit from the mouth. For the rear... ”ⲧ

—“Hmm, guys, what was the rear for again?”

He encourages them with his hands.

—“For emergencies only!!”

They all laugh, because it’s a little gross.

—“And so, eager to end their three-day fast, our intrepid duo steps outside Younā’s mouth,” he veers up as if in panic, “oh, no, straight into the maw of...”

They all gasp, and he hasn’t to wait too long for the inevitable question.

—“Who, Varaz?”

—“Evil Shamiram! For the Lion Queen of Sheba has warned her sister in secretive sororal solidarity.”

He is pretty sure that such a thing among queens exists, having been the subject of the queens’ inquisition a few times now. And believe you me, being questioned by queens, it feels like they can see through your bones. Especially those two *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens]—there are many queens at court, but only two are referred to with this elevated title: the dowager Queen, *Shāhān-Shāh* Husrow’s mother, and the *Shāhān-Shāh*’s third wife, *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Gordiyag. They are called that way because they are very scary! But also so awesome!

—“Is the evil Queen going to grab them, Varaz?”

—“Well, Āzar, I don’t know,” he is not lying, for he just came up with this twist too, “I’ll have to consult the Oracle of the Orb to find out. So, I will tell you guys next time.”

Of course, that is met with a lot of protest, but when it becomes clear he’s not going to tell more, they all start to leave. The first to slip away is of

³⁸Syriac Breviary, Rogation of the Ninevites.

course that puckish Abrangih girl. That's a fish he is going to catch later. For today, he had his fill of fish, ha, ha. Although, as usual, the *Bāmbishn* thinks differently. And so, after all the children have left, she tells him —“Rather than instituting the three-day Fast of Nainavā at the third iteration of the plague's outbreak, 23 years ago, *Katolikos* Ezekiel mocked his bishops for their misconception that fast not facts could solve such a problem. The Nainavā Rogation is still implemented every year by one school, while ridiculed by the other.”

—“Oh, I didn't know. *Spās*, Your Majesty.”

He has heard about this rivalry between the two Christian factions, between those that demand austerity through asceticism, while the others promote glorification through celebration. Like Queen Shirin, he is rooting for the latter to win, for instead of a meager loaf of bread, he can easily devour a whole pig now. He always gets so hungry after his stories! But that's perhaps because the children, they are the ones who devour his stories, ha, ha.